

# Activity Report 2022-23

**ABWCI**

Association of Business Women in Commerce & Industry

## Contents

|                                                                                  |            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>Section 1 - About ABWCI .....</b>                                             | <b>3</b>   |
| <b>Section 2 – Activities undertaken in the financial year<br/>2022-23 .....</b> | <b>5</b>   |
| <b>Section 3- Networking &amp; Outreach.....</b>                                 | <b>155</b> |
| <b>Section 4- Way Forward .....</b>                                              | <b>177</b> |

## **Section 1 - About ABWCI**

Association of Business Women in Commerce & Industry (ABWCI) is a section 8 company with its registered office in New Delhi. ABWCI aims to understand the needs of the future in the context of women entrepreneurship, be responsive to the challenges faced by women business-owners and assist businesswomen in the global economy to benefit from the opportunities that present themselves. The organization strives to create an enabling environment for women entrepreneurs and work towards their economic empowerment. Four access constraints have been observed in the women's economic world, such as access to market, access to finance, access to technology & access to entrepreneurial ecosystems.

Economies characterized by high levels of entrepreneurial activity are more resilient to financial crisis and experience economic slowdowns less frequently. Women entrepreneurship is a crucial part of future economic growth and employment generation. Women have excelled in making big gains and contributions to job growth and the global economy. ABWCI is a Chamber of Commerce for women working towards promoting women's economic security, empowerment, entrepreneurship development and business inclusion.

### **Vision**

ABWCI envisions to nurture and provide an enabling environment for women in business to build a sustainable and better future.

### **Mission**

Establish a collaborative ecosystem to engage, network, identify and leverage market opportunities globally.

### **Objectives**

ABWCI aims to bridge these gaps:

- To undertake skill development and livelihood programmes for women and youth from all the sectors
- To provide platform to help educate, build capacity for, and grow enterprises that are led by women, and that have a legally registered entity with their respective governments
- To collaborate with local organizations to identify women-led business owners, and work towards common goals of educating, building capacity, and growing women-led businesses
- To leverage local and global markets by categorizing businesses based on region, product/service, target demographic, status and building a high-yielding global network.
- To offer customized enterprise training and transformation initiatives tailored to meet the specific needs of women in business.

The current team of ABWCI has extensive experience of working on Women Empowerment Programmes. The rich and extensive experience of the team members of working on skill development and livelihood projects with communities across the country and with women entrepreneurs, is instrumental in furthering the agenda of Women's Economic Empowerment. ABWCI envisages to nurture and provide an enabling environment for women to build a sustainable and better future.

## Section 2 – Activities undertaken in the financial year 2022-23

### **ABWCI's Strategic Focus for 2022-23**

This year marked a crucial phase for ABWCI, as we continue to expand our efforts towards creating inclusive opportunities and empowering women and youth across diverse sectors. Our interventions this year were aligned with the broader goal of promoting sustainable development through targeted interventions, collaborative partnerships, and skill-building initiatives.

ABWCI's primary focus this year has been to enhance the employability and entrepreneurial capabilities of women and youth, particularly in rural and underserved areas. By organizing tailored entrepreneurship training programs, we aim to equip individuals with the skills necessary to pursue business ventures, fostering a culture of self-reliance. This initiative not only addresses the immediate need for economic opportunities but also creates a long-term impact on the socio-economic fabric of these communities.

Partnering with corporates under their CSR mandates was an important focus of our activities this year. Through these collaborations, we have initiated projects focused on upskilling women and supporting sustainable livelihoods. By aligning corporate resources with our social objectives, we were able to expand the reach of our programs, especially in rural belts where opportunities are often limited.

Recognizing the critical role of youth in driving future growth, ABWCI placed a strong emphasis on engaging with young individuals in universities. Another focal area has been the organization of thematic webinars and awareness campaigns. These events serve as platforms for dialogue on critical issues such as climate change, gender equality, and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

### **Empowering youth in colleges in Haryana**

ABWCI organized sessions with students in universities, conducted expert talks for students of three Universities - IILM, MDI and North Cap, on the subject of 'Challenges and Opportunities for women entrepreneurs.

Entrepreneurship training for college students is an important component of their

education as it equips them with the skills and knowledge needed to start and run successful businesses. ABWCI organized sessions and entrepreneurship events, invited successful entrepreneurs to speak on campus, and gave them an exposure to the following:

- Knowledge and skills needed to start and run a business.
- By connecting students with alumni who have started successful businesses.
- A culture of innovation – to inspire and motivate students to pursue their business ideas. This was done through direct interaction with entrepreneurs and would help in preparing the next generation of entrepreneurs and innovators, who will play a critical role in driving economic growth and creating jobs.



*Session in North Cap University on 'Empowering Women-The case of moder-day challenge'. The speakers Parul Soni, Arti Bindra and Nikita Arora, through their own entrepreneurial journey shared real-time experiences, learnings, challenges and opportunities. The session was participatory wherein students shared their views and observations.*



*Session in IILM University by Alka Batra, a successful first-generation entrepreneurs shared her experiences how she navigated entrepreneurial space and challenges she had to face as a woman, and ways to overcome them.*



*Session in IILM University with Arti Bindra, who spoke about business prospects in IT space and the key learnings from her journey. She emphasized the importance of seeing every situation as an opportunity to learn and succeed.*

The interactive sessions in colleges included practical examples and sharing of real-world scenarios by the experts, helped the youth understand and connect with the concepts of entrepreneurship more effectively.



- An expert session on “Urgency in Climate Action” was organized virtually for students at the Management Development Institute (MDI), Gurgaon and Ms. Erik Solheim, former Minister of Environment, Norway was the distinguished speaker for the talk.



*Session organized by ABWCI in collaboration with MDI University on ‘Urgency in Climate Action- Individuals Responsibilities’ The speakers discussed the tools and adaptation at an individual level to respond to the current situation.*

- 🚩 **Panel Discussion organized by ABWCI in May’2022, with ABWCI’s country and State Presidents of India and representatives from Youth CO:Lab, UNDP.**



### **Skill development and livelihood training to women in Odisha and Karnataka**

The skill development and livelihood training were undertaken within the Project – Hero for Humanity, which was implemented from June 2022- March 2023 for women who lost their husbands to Covid-19 pandemic. The project aimed to address the structural barriers and societal norms that prevent women from realizing their full economic potential, including discrimination in employment, unequal pay, and limited access to credit and capital. The programme focused on creating a supportive ecosystem for women providing them with the skills, resources, and networks necessary to succeed. This included training programs on skill development, financial management and livelihood set up. By increasing women's economic status, the project would help to promote gender equality and reduce poverty, benefiting not only women but also their families, communities, and the wider economy, thus contributing to accomplishing Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

In this phase women were provided monthly grocery kits as basic sustenance support and educational support (For children above 5 years of age). A total of 300 project beneficiaries were selected from both the States.

### **Entrepreneurship Development Training and setting up of enterprises by women in Odisha and Karnataka**

The training was undertaken in Phase II of project Hero for Humanity. The various livelihood options taken up by the women included setting up of *kirana store, tailoring unit, badi making unit, beauty parlor, disposable paper making unit, etc.* Some of the photos of the women who were trained and supported for setting up enterprises are given below who were supported under the project- Hero for humanity supported by Hero Motors.

Phase II entailed capacity building of the project beneficiaries, developing their skills and subsequently supporting them in setting up of enterprises for sustainable livelihood. 215 project beneficiaries of the above listed 300, were selected from Phase 1 of the project.



*ABWCI extended support to women who lost their husbands to Covid-19 pandemic to start a Kirana Store and a tailoring unit*



*ABWCI extended support to women who lost their husbands to Covid-19 pandemic to start a masala grinding unit and a tailoring Unit*





*ABWCI extended support to women who lost their husbands to Covid-19 pandemic to start a Kirana Store and a tailoring Unit*

### **Support for education of children of marginalized families**

Providing remedial education to children from the marginalized families in District – Kushi Nagar, Uttar Pradesh. The children receive subject-specific assistance, to reinforce concepts, clarify doubts, and provide extra practice. Study material and stationery is also provided to children from time to time. The small group sessions with these children encourage collaboration and peer learning, while one-on-one sessions with them provide individualized attention. The children are engaged in activities and exercises that promote analytical thinking and application of knowledge.

#### *Glimpses from the sessions with children in Kushi Nagar, UP*



*Stationery material provided to Children*





*Children after their regular class at Kushi Nagar, Uttar Pradesh*



The positive and supportive environment in the classes encourage active

participation, foster a growth mindset, and provide praise and encouragement to boost children's confidence.

### **State-Level Consultation with Private Sector Partners for Mainstreaming and Integration of SDGs in Partnership with UNDP India**

The SDG 2030 agenda calls on businesses, ranging from microenterprises to multinational corporations, to apply their creativity and innovation for solving sustainable development challenges.

The half day consultation was designed as a series of panel discussions focusing on: Strengthening the Skill Development, Employment and Livelihood Ecosystem Sustainable Energy, Environment and Resilience and Strengthening Start-up ecosystem with a focus on Technology and Innovation for social good

The sessions brought together key stakeholders from private sector and State Governments on a common platform to understand the development program implementation and their alignment with the UN's Sustainable Development Agenda 2030. The consultation concluded by exploring ways to collaborate and converge to address social challenges. The dialogues were launched in the year 2022, with the aim to create an environment addressing these challenges to get deeper insights into the speaker's entrepreneurial journey and their key takeaways. The dialogues are live streamed on you tube and serve as a good platform for audience to learn about business practices being followed and acquaint them with business options depending on the availability of resources.



## Section 3- Networking & Outreach

### ABWCI Dialogues/Expert Talks (Virtual)



- Participation in virtual Sankalp Global Summit as 'Outreach partner' and hosted a session on Women Entrepreneurs Impacting Lives and Contributing to Growth'
- ABWCI has formed alliance with several institutes in the year 2022-23 , to provide women entrepreneurs a platform to help educate, build capacity for, and grow businesses. We have partnered with the following organizations/institutions to support Women Entrepreneurs.

- ✓ IIFPT (Indian Institute of Food Processing Technology)
- ✓ The Sikh Chamber of Commerce
- ✓ The SSE (School for Social Entrepreneurs India)
- ✓ Key Disruptors Pvt. Ltd.
- ✓ TSCC (The Sikh Chamber of Commerce)
- ✓ U2CA (U2CA Consultants Pvt. Ltd.)
- ✓ AIC - BAMU (Atal Incubation Center - Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Marathwada University)
- ✓ IILM University
- ✓ MDI University
- ✓ North Cap University
- ✓ Bihar Entrepreneurship Association
- ✓ Mash Projects- Mash Advisory Pvt. Lts
- ✓ Hyderabad Management Association
- ✓ IMS Foundation - Laghu Udyog Bharati
- ✓ Ubuntu Consortium of Women Entrepreneurs Association
- ✓ AIC-Raise (Atal Incubation Centre Coimbatore)
- ✓ Buddy Foundation
- ✓ Sankalp Intellicap
- ✓ Sense legal LLP
- ✓ Arcanus Serices Pvt. Ltd
- ✓ Aurora Business School, Hyderabad
- ✓ De-Asra Foundation

### **Footprints**

The list of Indian states, where ABWCI has presence is as follows:

1. Tamil Nadu & Puducherry
2. Rajasthan
3. Delhi-NCR
4. Punjab
5. Telangana & Andhra Pradesh
6. Odisha
7. Assam
8. Haryana
9. Uttar Pradesh
10. Himachal Pradesh
11. Uttarakhand
12. Bihar & Jharkhand
13. Maharashtra

## **Section 4- Way Forward**

ABWCI remains committed to fostering economic independence, social resilience, and gender equality. Through strategic collaborations, we aim to create a more equitable and inclusive society where women succeed as entrepreneurs, leaders, and change-makers.

ABWCI aims to equip women with the skills, resources, and support needed to start and sustain successful enterprises. The focus would be on creating pathways for women from both urban and rural areas to engage in entrepreneurship, contributing to economic growth and fostering self-reliance.

We envision building an inclusive entrepreneurial ecosystem that offers continuous support, mentorship, and networking opportunities. This ecosystem will provide women entrepreneurs from all backgrounds with the opportunities to collaborate, innovate, and grow.

Strategy for the coming year would focus on collaborating with organizations, institutions, and individuals who share the vision of empowering women. By leveraging collective resources, these partnerships will help create a scalable and sustainable impact that ensures long-term success for women entrepreneurs.